

BASTIANICH FAMILY

It is undeniable that Italian food and wine have always had a strong cultural connection to the Bastianich family's roots and history.

Pioneers in importing excellent Italian wines to the United States since the early 70s, they eventually became producers in 1997 in the DOC Friuli Colli Orientali with the Bastianich Winery in Cividale del Friuli.

The family's story begins in Istria, a peninsula on the northeastern coast of the Adriatic Sea, once Italian territory and now divided between Slovenia and Croatia. The years following World War II were not easy for the Bastianich family, leading Mrs. Erminia, Joe's maternal grandmother, to flee from Tito's regime, seeking a better future for her family.

They spent two years in the Risiera di San Sabba refugee camp in Trieste under challenging conditions before finding work and acceptance in New York. There, they tried to recreate what they had left behind, with the few belongings and memories they carried with them.

Among homemade wine demijohns, cured meats, and a garden rich in radicchio, pumpkins, fruit trees, and everything that reminded them of *home*. Felice and Lidia Bastianich, parents of *Restaurant Man* Joe Bastianich, opened their first restaurant in 1971, *Buonavia* in Queens, followed by *Villasecondo* and, in 1981, by *Felidia* in Manhattan, which soon became the temple of true traditional and regional Italian cuisine in the Big Apple.

Once grown, Joe spent a sabbatical year in Italy, working in the cellars and vineyards of the greatest producers of the time (and beyond!) and a year in Palermo at the Micieli Company. After planting vineyards in Pantelleria, learning the basics of the wine world from North to South Italy, harvesting in Montalcino and Bolgheri, Joe returned to NY to open his first restaurant. His path has led him today to manage more than twenty restaurants worldwide, as well as entrepreneurial projects related to the Italian food world such as *Eataly United States*, and a television, authorial, and musical career that spans between Italy and the USA.

Joe wanted to buy, with his family, the first vineyards in Italy at the birth of his firstborn, Olivia, because he wanted his children to finally — after so many years — have a place in Italy they could call *home*, starting from an area suited to great whites. Today, the Bastianich Winery produces around 230,000 bottles per year, exported to more than 28 countries.

